

Great Smoky Mountains NATIONAL PARK

TENNESSEE-NORTH CAROLINA

OPEN ALL YEAR

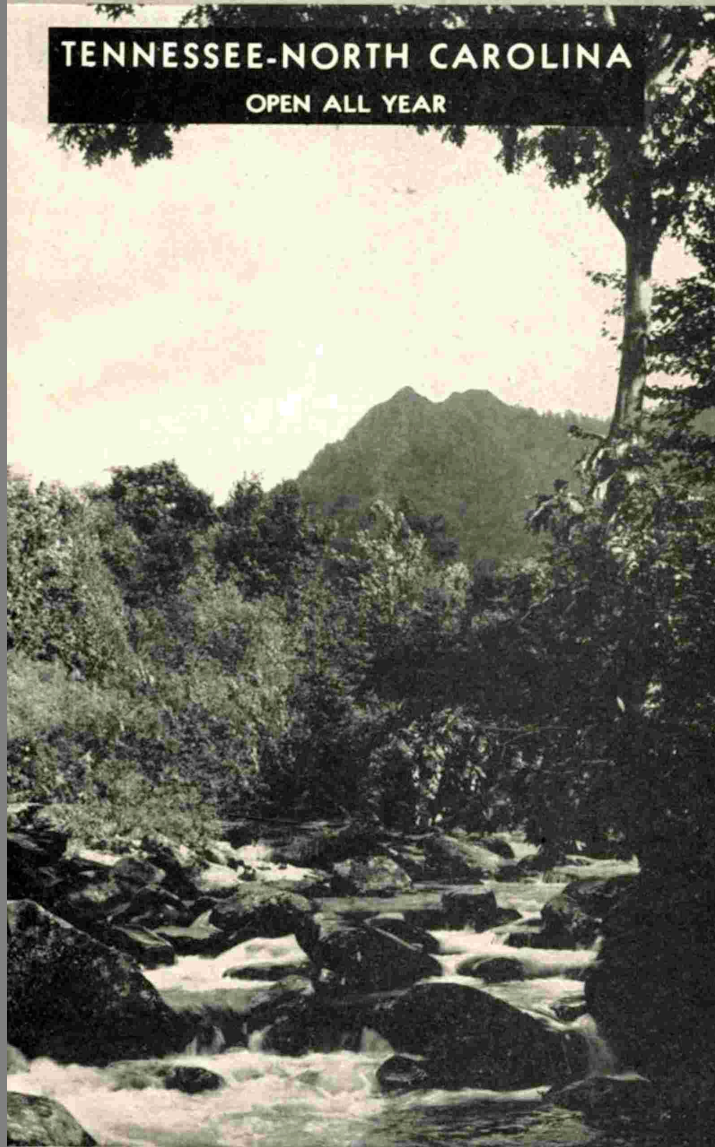


UNITED STATES DEPARTMENT OF THE
INTERIOR • Douglas McKay, *Secretary*
NATIONAL PARK SERVICE • Conrad L. Wirth, *Director*

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*** START OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK GREAT SMOKY
MOUNTAINS NATIONAL PARK ***

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Great Smoky Mountains NATIONAL PARK

The National Park System, of which this park is a unit, is dedicated to conserving the scenic, scientific, and historic heritage of the United States for the benefit and enjoyment of its people.

GREAT SMOKY MOUNTAINS NATIONAL PARK is located on the crest of the high divide which forms the boundary between Tennessee and North Carolina. This mountain range, representing one of the oldest uplands on earth, zigzags through the park from northeast to southwest for 71 miles, or 54 miles by air line. For 36 miles along its main crest the range maintains an altitude in excess of 5,000 feet. Sixteen of its peaks rise more than 6,000 feet. The deep blue haze rising from the valleys to the summits of the lofty peaks gives these mountains their name.



View from Heintooga Overlook.

Renowned for its splendid forests and containing a rich variety of plant life, the Great Smokies region has long been regarded by prominent botanists as the cradle of the present vegetation of eastern America.

Arnold Guyot, eminent scientist whose exploration of the Appalachian System began a century ago, was the first to describe the Great Smoky Mountains from personal observation. He wrote:

“Although the high peaks of the Smoky mountains are some fifty feet lower than the isolated and almost exceptional group of the Black mountains, by their number, their magnitude, the continuity and general elevation of the chains, and of the base upon which they repose, they are like a massive and high citadel which is really the culminating region of all the Appalachian System.”

History of the Park

Prior to the start of the 20th century, the area now comprising the park was little known to the outside world, although DeSoto is believed to have viewed the mountains. They were, and still are, the home of the Cherokees who now occupy the Cherokee Indian Reservation in North Carolina, adjacent to the park on the south. The few white settlers were the rugged mountaineer descendants of colonists from England and Scotland who lived isolated and primitive lives. The Great Smokies region became better known during and subsequent to World War I when logging railroads of lumber companies penetrated some of its virgin forests. Still later, highways skirted the area and visitors were able to view its majestic peaks from a distance.

The successful movement for the creation of a national park in this area was begun in 1923, and its establishment was authorized by the Federal Government by act of Congress approved May 22, 1926. Enabling acts were passed by the State legislatures of North Carolina and Tennessee in 1927, and land acquisition was begun with State funds, matched by a generous donation made by John D. Rockefeller, Jr., through the Laura Spelman Rockefeller Memorial, in honor of his mother. Subsequently, Federal funds were made available for the completion of the project.

On February 6, 1930, the Governors of North Carolina and Tennessee presented the Secretary of the Interior with deeds to an initial 158,876 acres of land on behalf of their respective States. A limited park was thus established for administration and protection. The park, now containing 507,168 acres of Federal lands, was formally dedicated on September 2, 1946.

Pioneer Culture in the Great Smokies

Great Smoky Mountains National Park presents an opportunity to preserve frontier conditions of a century ago. The cultural and human interest aspects of this park are exceeded only by its scenery and natural history.

In places where the forest has not yet encroached upon them, there are clearings which were the sloping little farms of the mountain pioneers. Sturdy log structures in varying stages of disintegration remain there as evidence of a way of life which has practically disappeared in eastern United States. Some of these log cabins, barns, and other buildings have been rehabilitated in place so that you may see the original structures in their true setting. Most of them are in Cades Cove, where the park's only grist mill powered by an overshot wheel is located. Cades Cove, an isolated, oval-shaped valley surrounded by mountains, is a region of outstanding pastoral charm which you should visit.

Some of the finest of various types of authentic pioneer structures have been assembled in the immediate vicinity of the Oconaluftee Ranger Station and Pioneer Museum, located on the cross-mountain highway about 2 miles north of Cherokee, N. C. On display in the museum are tools, household objects, and a variety of other handmade items which were used by the pioneers who made their homes on lands which now comprise the park. This building is open from 9 a. m. to 5 p. m., April through October.

The Cherokee Indian Reservation

You will be interested in the Cherokee Indians on the Cherokee Reservation, which is immediately south of the park. Although the Government has instituted here a comprehensive system of education and modern methods of living, ancient ceremonies and sports are preserved as tribal customs.



THOMPSON PHOTO

Rhododendron along the trail to Mount Le Conte.

Forests

Crowning the highest peaks with spruce and fir and carpeting the mountainsides with a wealth of deciduous trees is an unbroken forest cover, which cannot be matched in eastern America. In all of Europe there are not as many species of native trees as are to be found in Great Smoky Mountains National Park. A number of these, such as Canada hemlock, silverbell, red spruce, yellow buckeye, and mountain-ash grow to record size, while others become giants of their kind. Approximately 40 percent of the more than half-million acres which comprise the park are in the original forested condition. A total of 130 native tree species are known to grow in this area.

Other Plant Life

Few, if any, areas in the eastern United States possess so great a variety of plants. Altogether, the tree, shrub, and herb varieties total more than 1,300. Botanists have also listed over 1,800 species of fungi, 330 mosses and liverworts, and 230 lichens. The earliest flowers occasionally appear by the close of February in lowland areas, while the witchhazel, latest to bloom, may hold its blossoms into December. Late April finds the spring flowers, including the abundant dogwood, at their blossoming peak; May is best for the mountain laurel; middle June usually finds both the flame azalea and rose-purple rhododendron at their finest; middle July is likely to be the peak of the great white rhododendron's flowering. Autumn colors are excellent throughout October, with the height of coloration near the end of the month.

A Wildlife Sanctuary

Here, as in all national parks, wildlife is given complete protection. No hunting or trapping is permitted. Since establishment of the park, the black bear population has increased considerably, and such animals as the white-tailed deer, red and gray foxes, raccoon, bobcat, wild turkey, ruffed grouse, and others find sanctuary in these mountains. More than 52 species of fur-bearing animals, some 200 birds, 36 reptiles, 37 amphibians, and 80 fishes are known to live here.

The feeding, touching, teasing, or molesting of bears is prohibited. This regulation is enforced strictly for the protection of the public. Persons using park trails have nothing to fear from unmolested bears. If tempted by food, however, some bears, which frequent sections of the motor road, become dangerous. They should not be fed or approached. Persons using the Appalachian Trail shelters can protect their food supplies by suspending them from tree limbs outside the shelter.

Fishing

Approximately 600 miles of streams, many of them well suited to trout, flow down the slopes of the Great Smoky Mountains. Each year thousands of hatchery-reared trout are released in the more heavily fished waters. Rainbow and brook trout and small-mouth bass lure the devotees of Izaak Walton. Persons fishing in park waters must have the State or county license issued and required by North Carolina, or the State license issued and required by Tennessee, depending upon the section of the park being fished. Catches are regulated, and some streams may be found closed for restocking. The fishing season is from May 16 to August 31. Current regulations may be obtained from the office of the superintendent or from park rangers or wardens.

Interpretive Service

Beginning in May and continuing for 6 months, a program of naturalist-guided field trips and talks is available. This service is maintained by the Government and is free to the public.

Naturalists meet hikers at designated points in or near the park and conduct visits to outstanding objectives over good trails. Plant and animal life is discussed informally along the way. There are several types of walks ranging from 2 hours to all day. Illustrated talks are given in the evenings at regular intervals, chiefly in hotel lobbies and other points of visitor-concentration.

Programs describing the nature-guide service are available (May-October) at headquarters and at Oconaluftee Ranger Station and are posted in hotels and various places throughout the park.

Accommodations

Free modern campgrounds are provided on the Tennessee side of the park at the Chimney Tops, 6 miles south of Gatlinburg, and Cades Cove, 7 miles from the Townsend entrance to the park; on the North Carolina side at Smokemont, on the transmountain highway, Balsam Mountain, 10 miles from Soco Gap on U. S. 19 (Blue Ridge Parkway spur), and Deep Creek, 2 miles from Bryson City. Aside from these campgrounds, the only accommodations in the park are at Le Conte Lodge on the top of Mount Le Conte, accessible only by foot or horseback. For reservations and rates, write Jack Huff, Gatlinburg, Tenn.

A number of hotel and tourist courts are available in cities and towns near the park, and at Knoxville and Asheville. Inquiries regarding these accommodations should be addressed to Knoxville Tourist Bureau, Henley Street, Knoxville, Tenn.; East Tennessee Automobile Club, Knoxville, Tenn., Chambers of Commerce of Gatlinburg, Knoxville, and Maryville, Tenn., Asheville, Waynesville, Bryson City, and Sylva, N. C.; Cherokee Association, Cherokee, N. C.; and Government Services, Inc., Fontana Village, Fontana Dam, N. C.

Administration

Great Smoky Mountains National Park is administered by the National Park Service of the United States Department of the Interior. A superintendent, whose address is Gatlinburg, Tenn., is in immediate charge. Park headquarters are located 2 miles south of Gatlinburg. A member of the protection division maintains headquarters at Oconaluftee Ranger Station, N. C., on U. S. 441; post office, Cherokee, N. C.



THOMPSON PHOTO

Newfound Gap, highest point on the transmountain highway.

Help Us Protect This Park

Please note the following requirements which are necessary for the protection of the natural beauties of the park, as well as for your comfort and convenience:

The park is a sanctuary for all living things. It is a violation of the law to destroy, injure, or disturb trees, shrubs, flowers, birds, animals, or any natural feature in the park.

The speed limit is 35 miles an hour, unless otherwise posted. Drive carefully; keep to the right. Report all accidents to a park ranger.

Camping or lighting fires at places other than designated campgrounds or picnic areas is not allowed, except by permit. To camp in remote sections of the park, except during periods of high fire hazard, permits may be secured at the office of the superintendent, the Oconaluftee Ranger Station, or from the district park rangers or wardens. Camping is restricted to certain periods at the campgrounds. Individual sites provided with fireplaces and water are available.

Please help to keep the park clean. Do not scatter papers, picnic remnants, and the like; use trash receptacles along roads, in picnic areas, and campgrounds.

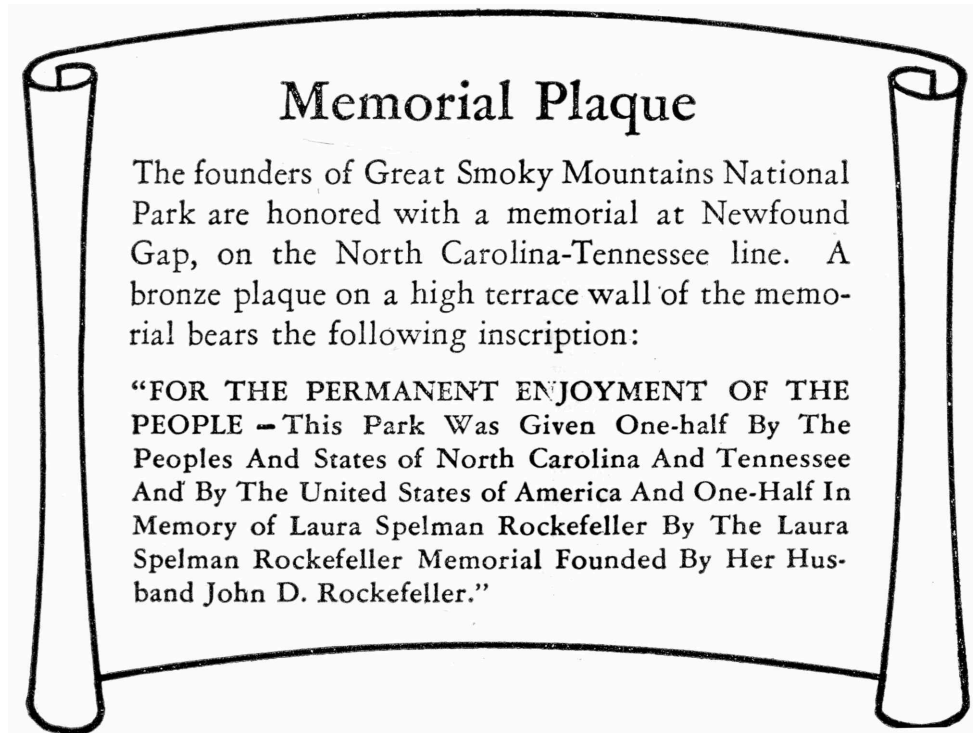
Fire is one of the greatest dangers to the park. Put out fires completely upon leaving. Be sure cigarettes and matches are out before disposal. Lunches may be eaten along roadsides, but fires should not be built.

Only those persons having special permits may collect botanical or geological specimens in the park. Such permits may be secured by competent scientists upon application to the superintendent.

Dogs and cats are permitted in the park if on leash, crated, or otherwise under physical restrictive control at all times.

The feeding, touching, teasing, or molesting of bears is prohibited.

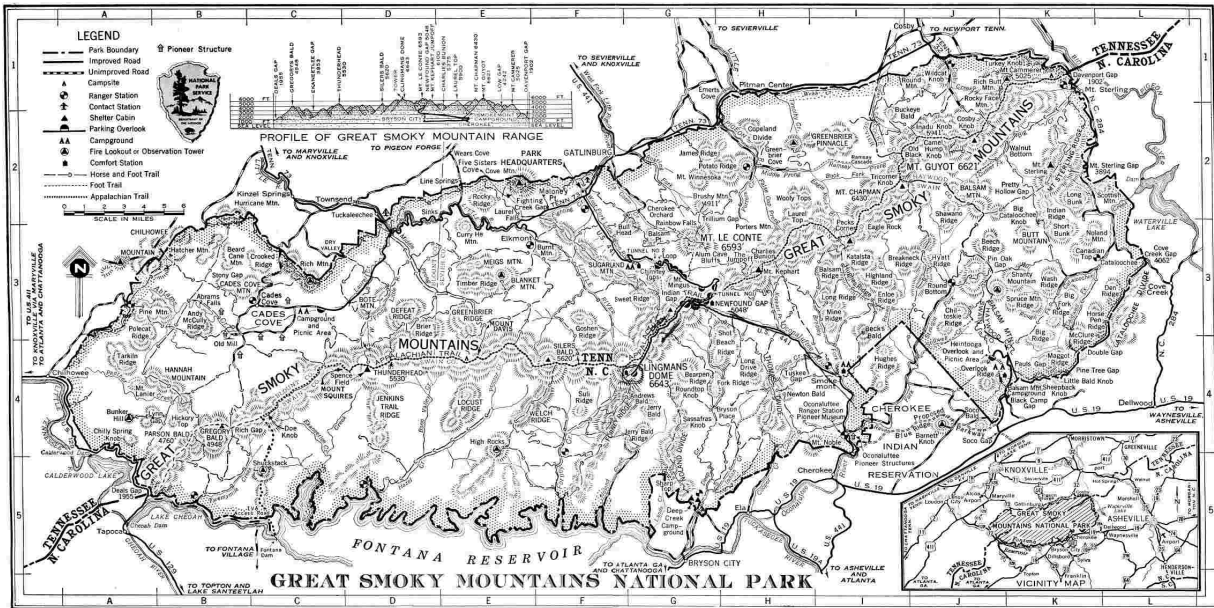
Deliberate infraction of park regulations may bring penalty of fine or imprisonment or both.



Memorial Plaque

The founders of Great Smoky Mountains National Park are honored with a memorial at Newfound Gap, on the North Carolina-Tennessee line. A bronze plaque on a high terrace wall of the memorial bears the following inscription:

“FOR THE PERMANENT ENJOYMENT OF THE PEOPLE—This Park Was Given One-half By The Peoples And States of North Carolina And Tennessee And By The United States of America And One-Half In Memory of Laura Spelman Rockefeller By The Laura Spelman Rockefeller Memorial Founded By Her Husband John D. Rockefeller.”



GREAT SMOKY MOUNTAINS NATIONAL PARK

COMPLETELY EXTINGUISH MATCHES AND CIGARETTES BEFORE
THROWING AWAY.
BE SURE CAMPFIRE IS OUT BEFORE LEAVING IT.
ALWAYS USE CAR ASHTRAYS.
LET'S NOT BE GUILTY OF STARTING A FOREST FIRE.

To—	From—			Elevation	Remarks	Map Index
	Gatlinburg entrance	Cherokee entrance	Townsend entrance			
	Miles	Miles	Miles	Feet		
Park Headquarters	1.5	28.3	18.5	1463	Office of superintendent	F-2.
Pioneer Museum and Oconaluftee Ranger Station	27.9	1.9	45.9	2025	Museum; park office, North Carolina section	I-4.
Chimneys Campground	6.5	23.6	23.5	2750	In Tennessee section on U. S. 441	G-3.
Smokemont Campground	24.6	5.2	41.5	2198	In North Carolina section on U. S. 441	I-4.
Balsam Mountain Campground	53.3	23.5	71.3	5340	In North Carolina section; 11.3 miles north of U. S. 19	J-4.
Cades Cove Campground	26	63	7.7	1960	In Tennessee section; 7 miles south of Tennessee Route 73	C-3.
Deep Creek Campground	45.8	16	63.8	1800	In North Carolina section; 2.1 miles north of U. S. 19	G-5.

Heintooga Ridge Picnic Area	53.8	24	71.8	5325	Excellent mountain vistas	J-4.
Chimneys Footbridge	8.7	21.1	25.7	3550	At parking area above lower tunnel	G-3.
Alum Cave Parking Area	10.5	19.3	27.5	3850	Trail to Alum Cave Bluffs and Mount Le Conte	G-3.
Cherokee Orchard	4.7	35.5	24.7	2550	Trails to Mount Le Conte and Rainbow Falls	G-2.
Newfound Gap	15	14.8	42	5048	Where U. S. 441 crosses Smokies, Appalachian Trail, and Clingmans Dome Highway	G-3.
Indian Gap	16.3	16.1	43.3	5266	Historic pass through Smokies	G-3.
Forney Ridge Parking Area	22.5	22.3	49.5	6311	Clingmans Dome Trail	G-4.
Fighting Creek Gap	4.6	31.4	15.4	2320	Trail to Laurel Falls and Cove Mountain	F-2.
Cherokee Indian Reservation	31.3	1.5	48.5	1900	Eastern band of Cherokee Indians	I-5.
Little River Gorge	5.8	32.5	1	2000	Scenic drive	E-2 and D-2.
Cades Cove	26	63	7.7	1807	Extensive level area surrounded by mountains	C-3.
Tremont "Y"	18.2	45	0.7	1147	Junction of Cades Cove and Little River Roads	D-3.
Greenbrier	11	43	31	1680	Trails into area of excellent forests and streams	H-2.
Cosby	23.1	52	43.1	2459	Northeastern section of park, Tennessee side	J-1.
Cataloochee	50.4	60.5	70.4	2643	Excellent scenic drive, eastern section of park	K-3.
Loop trip around western end of park	165	165	165		One-day drive, Gatlinburg to park headquarters, Elkmont, Townsend, Maryville, Tapoca, Bryson City, Cherokee, and Gatlinburg	

How To Reach the Park

Paved highways from all States converge at Knoxville, Tenn., and Asheville, N. C. Bus lines maintain service to both cities. The Southern Railway and the Louisville & Nashville Railroad serve Knoxville; the former also serves Asheville. Knoxville may also be reached by American, Capital (PCA), and Delta Airlines; Asheville, by Capital (PCA), Delta, and Piedmont Airlines. Trailways buses make seven trips each way, daily, between Knoxville and Asheville, going through the park via Gatlinburg and Cherokee. North Carolina towns bordering the park may be reached by direct buses from Atlanta and Chattanooga. Excursions by bus also may be made from Knoxville, stopping overnight at Gatlinburg and continuing to Knoxville via Maryville, Tenn. Smoky Mountain Tours, Inc., with offices in both Knoxville and Asheville, operate personally conducted sightseeing stages through the park between the two cities frequently during the summer. The Southern Railway offers both one-way and round-trip tickets, providing travel by bus through the park between Knoxville and Asheville.

The Seasons

Summer days are usually warm or hot in the lowland areas and cool in the higher mountains; the nights are cool.

Spring arrives early in the lowland areas and progressively later at higher elevations. Weather conditions are particularly favorable in autumn, with less rainfall at that season. Winters are variable, both as to severity and length, but they normally are mild in the lowlands.

Rain, snow, and fog often are encountered in the mountains during the winter. Roads are kept open all year, but the transmountain highway sometimes is closed for a few hours during heavy snow or sleet storms when snowplows cannot keep it open. Snows are infrequent in the park, but you should take chains if you plan to drive through in winter. Roads are posted if driving conditions are unfavorable.

Horses, Pack Animals, and Guide Service

In some of the towns bordering the park, horses and pack animals, with guide service, may be rented by the hour, day, or for longer periods.

Destination	Trail starts	Elevation	Distance round trip	Remarks	Map Index
		<i>Feet</i>	<i>Miles</i>		
Laurel Falls	Fighting Creek Gap	2500	2.5	One of the most popular hiking trips	E-2.
Clingmans Dome Summit	Forney Ridge Parking Area	6643	1	One-half mile paved trail leads to one of the highest peaks in East; highest in park.	G-4.
Andrews Bald	Forney Ridge Parking Area	5860	4	One of the most popular hikes in park.	G-4.
Alum Cave Bluffs	Alum Cave Parking Area	4900	5	Easy trail, fine views. Best for rose-purple rhododendron in mid-June. Alum Cave Bluffs.	G-3.
Mount Le Conte: via Alum Cave Bluffs	Alum Cave Parking Area	6593	10.4	Shortest way to Mount Le Conte and very spectacular. Foot trail only.	G-3.
via Boulevard	Newfound Gap	6593	16	Follows Appalachian Trail to Mount Kephart and thence along Boulevard Trail to Le Conte.	G-3.
via Cherokee Orchard	Cherokee Orchard via Rainbow Falls	6593	13.4	Trail passes Rainbow Falls and around Rocky Spur.	G-3.
	Cherokee Orchard via Bullhead	6593	14.4	Trail passes around Bullhead.	G-3.
	Cherokee Orchard via Trillium Gap	6593	16.8	Good horse trail.	G-3.
via Roaring Fork	Gatlinburg and Trillium Gap	6593	22.4	Longest trip to Mount Le Conte, but interesting.	G-3.
The Jumpoff	Newfound Gap	6100	6.5	Jagged mountain peaks.	H-3.
Charlies Bunion	Newfound Gap	5375	8.6	Reminiscent of the rugged Rockies.	H-3.
Gregory Bald	Cades Cove	4948	11	Best display of wild azalea in mid-June.	B-4.

Chimney Tops	Chimneys Bridge	4755	3	For the experienced hiker. 3 hours, round trip.	G-3.
Mount Cammerer	Davenport Gap	5025	12	Fine view of valleys and mountains.	K-1.
Ramsey Cascades	Greenbrier	4750	12	Largest cascades; stands of virgin hardwoods.	I-2.
Raven Fork Wilderness	Smokemont	4202	16	Largest stand of virgin red spruce and balsam.	J-3.
Mount Sterling Tower	Mount Sterling Gap	5835	5.2	Accessible fire tower.	K-2.
Sharp Top on Noland Divide	Bryson City (at park line)	3430	4	Interesting hike.	G-5.
Bryson Place	Bryson City	2411	20	Follows Deep Creek to Bryson Place, and Nettle Creek into a fine stand of virgin hardwoods.	H-4.

Roads and Trails

There are 66 miles of high standard roads in the park including the transmountain highway from Gatlinburg, Tenn., to Cherokee, N. C. Clingmans Dome Highway reaches an altitude of 6,311 feet. Seventy miles of secondary roads and 653 miles of horse and foot trails are available for hiking and riding.

The park highways offer exceptional opportunities to view the grandeur of the Great Smokies. Spur roads and trails lead to many points of interest.

There are trails of all types to suit your individual requirements. Some are 4 feet wide on easy gradients; some are improved footpaths; others merely tracks through the forest. Park forces try to keep trails drained and clear of brush and other obstacles; but the country is rough, and hikers should wear suitable outdoor clothing, including stout low-heeled shoes. If you are an inexperienced hiker, you should be especially careful and watch your footing on the trails.

The Appalachian Trail

The Appalachian Trail crosses the park and follows the ridge of the Smokies for most of its 71 miles. The eastern portion, from Davenport Gap at the northeast corner to Newfound Gap on the transmountain highway, is 31 miles long and follows through an absolute wilderness. The western portion from Newfound Gap to Fontana Dam just outside the park, is 40 miles long. Most of the trail is over 5,000 feet in elevation.

There are 7 trailside shelters and 3 trailside campsites along the 71-mile section of the Appalachian Trail in this park from Davenport Gap to Newfound Gap (31 miles) and Newfound Gap to Fontana Dam (40 miles). These are nearly equally spaced for 1-day hiking trips. Shelters are closed on 3 sides and provide simple bunk accommodations for 6 persons. A fireplace is in front and water is available nearby. Use of the shelters is normally restricted to 1 night. Camping is permitted along the trail only at the above points and a camping permit for each trip is required. (See [page 8](#).) Because of the scarcity of fuel at these sites, you are advised to carry primus-type stoves.

*** END OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK GREAT SMOKY
MOUNTAINS NATIONAL PARK ***

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